

COUNSELLING SKILLS

WHAT IS COUNSELLING? (SLIDE 1)

A lot of time we come across in our day to day life of people using the word counselling which according to most of them is giving advice to people in need and providing them guidance, but the art of counselling is more than just providing guidance to people of our know when they are in need of it.

Easily put counselling refers to giving out professional help, a sense of caring for the client, talking effectively, listening empathetically and solving the problems intelligently.

When we refer to professional help we imply to assist the client through mastered skills and techniques which bring a result in the client. The help will only be effective and have a result when the client requires it and ask you to help them. This also includes the professional relationship that we have with the client and follow the ethics that are required out of a professional counsellor while counselling others.

Counselling has a sense of caring personally towards the other client to the extent that they feel a sense of safety with you in a non-threatening environment. In order to do this you must show non-judgemental mind set towards the other client, you accept the client and the situation they are in as they are and be genuine in the caring that you show towards them. When the client feels this sense of caring it becomes easier for us to earn their trust which is important for the counselling process.

It also includes talking. When we say talking it need not necessarily be that you talk a lot with the client who seeks your counsel. Talking effectively refers to the ability to change the other client's opinion. In order to do this it is important that while talking to the client about their issues and challenges we give them solutions that are factually correct, are achievable and are realistic in nature.

Counselling also refers to listening empathetically where you put yourself in the other person's shoes in a manner that you get them talking and as they do so in the process they give out information which they might be hesitant to do so initially when they come to speak with you. This information given by them helps you as a counsellor in analysing the challenge that they are facing and the easier the problem to analyse the quicker you will be able to help them solve it.

The art of counselling also includes helping the client solve the challenge intelligently. Remember that you need not find permanent solutions to temporary problems. The counselling process becomes more effective and efficient when you look for nearest and easiest solutions to challenges are mild in nature, An example of this can be time management where you can give simple tips to make out extra time for the client so that they can have some me time from their busy day at work so that they may have a sense of rest throughout their busy day.

COUNSELLING AS A “SKILL” (SLIDE 2)

When we say “counselling skill” we refer to a set of abilities that are learned over a period of time by the professional which they have mastered and have put to use for the benefit of their clients. Simply put a skill is an act which is learned laboriously, practiced tirelessly, proved and used regularly.

Students who wish to learn counselling as a skill go through vigorous training throughout different parts of the world where they learn the skill through hard labour and are constantly brushed up on the knowledge of counselling. There are provided appropriate knowledge through their mentors and teachers who train them to acquire the skill so that they may use it in their professional life. Acquiring such skill takes time an effort and it does not happen over time. Some skills can be very tricky to administer with the client as it becomes difficult to analyse which set of the skills will work with them therefore it is important that to learn the mentor of the professional provides constant guidance.

The skill of counselling is also practiced tirelessly. Most of the time teachers or mentors ask the students learning the skill to conduct mock sessions among one another and the teacher observes them. After they have had the dummy session the teacher will analyse the session and will point out the mistakes made and will provide them with the appropriate techniques. The skill of counselling is better learned on the field rather than just with books and notes. It is practiced time and again even when you do not want to.

Counselling skills are also proven regularly. For learning the skill merely learning and practicing them is not enough. It is also important that they be proved to the mentors or to the professionals themselves. Students often prove to their teacher that they have acquired a particular skill when they excel in practical and written tests while as a professional you succeed in proving the skill when your clients come back to you, are happy with the help that you provide them with and also refer you to other people. This shows that you are not only proving to yourself that you have the ability to help and guide others but are also excelling at it.

The skills that are learned practiced and prove are also use on a timely basis as in the field of counselling it is very important that we constantly keep ourselves updated with any new upcoming techniques that are useful and that might work for the client that we deal with on a daily basis. Using the skills in a timely manner also helps you to sharpen up on them and make any improvising that you may find necessary once you are well versed in the field of counselling.

Thus to acquire and master the various skills of counselling it takes time, effort and patience which is analysed and changed over period of time with the changing needs of the field.

WHAT DO COUNSELLORS DO? (SLIDE 3)

Many times when clients come to us their current concerns might be different than the actual concerns that they are actually facing. It is important that as counsellors that we make them realize what their underlying problems are.

The immediate response to the client should be to neutralize the pain that they are facing for their immediate comfort so that they may be able to lead you on to the underlying problem in the future sessions. It is important to do so as while speaking with you the client is in a neutral frame of mind where he/she are neither too happy or neither too sad as this may even lead to over amplifying their current problem which may not be very serious in nature. This will also help the client feel calm and not anxious which they initially feel while seeking help.

Harmonize the client with the problem. Make sure that you bring the problem at hand to the client's awareness with appropriate techniques of listening, questioning and paraphrasing.

Motivate the client with what is left. This kind of motivation is different with the motivation done by other people. Here it is very important that you motivate the client with reality and be genuine with him/her. In doing so you help the client set realistic goals with whatever available resources that they have.

Activate them. There are four kinds of change that generally happen with a client, a change of knowledge, attitude, and result. If the client does not make a change in the action or does not take action to change his current situation, the therapeutic interventions provided by you will fail thus it also depends on how you motivate the client to make the change in his life as mentioned above. Remember that change will only occur when you take an action and not just think and plan about it.

Next is unlocking the client's personality and hidden abilities. Here the client plays an active role while there is less control on the counsellors part as the realization and the change has to come from the client's side and the counsellor can just facilitate the change and finding out the hidden traits that the client possess which may help him/ her with coping strategies and help the client deal with the problematic situation.

Remember that while dealing with clients to be human and to know that the session may not go as per plan and the schedule. Try your best to help them.

THE "R" FACTOR OR THE RESOLUTION FACTOR. (SLIDE 4 & 5)

Realize the client's problem. When the client comes to you with his/her problem do not brush them away by saying that the problem is not very serious in nature or are not of significance. Instead wait for the client to finish talking and take your time with them to analyse the problem. Acknowledge the problem that the client initially comes with, to you.

Relook. Help the client relook at the solution given to them from time to time and provide them with proper feedback about their action. Try to get them to see a new perspective to their challenge and by doing so they may be able to look at the bright side of the situation

which will help them to cope with the problem. Make them understand and see a new viewpoint.

Recover. Help the client recover with their loss and instead supplement it with another source with the lost factor in a healthy manner. Give this time to the client to help them gain themselves and to have some time to work upon themselves so that they may be able to face the challenge that they are dealing with at that point of time. Do not set a time period for the client to recover as each client takes their own time to regain them back. However maintain a balance that the client does not take too much time as they might be also escaping from the situation. Help them recover slowly by taking one step at a time.

Reset. Try resetting the current situation of the client, for example you can give the suggestion to the client to take a holiday for some time which will physically change the environmental setting for him/her thereby giving chance for them to have some time to regain their composure. This can be a little difficult at times as it can take time for the client to learn the different coping skills where he/she can change or reset themselves emotionally.

Repeat: Ask the client to repeat the solutions that they used in their past to the current problem. This will help the client in reshaping the solution to the new challenge thereby decreasing the dependency of you as a counsellor. It will also increase their self-esteem and give them a sense of achievement when they solve the problem successfully themselves.

Reassure. Give the client a sense of hope that you are there with them for support and reassure them that change is possible and by bringing out the minute change that they make within themselves, bring it to their notice so that they be assured that they have the ability to make the change happen. Reassuring the client also gives them a sense of safety which allows them to trust you more as a professional counsellor and thereby strengthens the bond that you have with them as a professional and a client.

Repair. Help the client repair what has been broken, whether it is a change of school, or a break up from a relation, if it's a loss of a loved one or a fight with the parents, help the client fill the void which has been left by the person or at times a pet have left behind. Some times this void can be even due to changes in situation or even a prized possession, it is very important that the blankness that is felt by the client needs to be filled in a healthier manner which helps the client to carry on in life and look towards the future.

Reengineer. This is very similar to breaking an already made puzzle which the client was not happy with and remaking it from the scratch along with the client to the extent that the client feels happy and satisfied with the outcome of remaking the puzzle. Similarly if the client is not happy or disturbed with their current situation help them rebuild it piece by piece till they are satisfied and content with it.

Regenerate. By this we mean that as a professional counsellor we should help the client regenerate the immediate and critical resources that is required for the client to move forward and face the challenging situation.

RULES OF CHANGE IN COUNSELLING (SLIDE 6)

Improvement and development in the client's situation can be seen by a few changes that the client makes which the therapist helps them to do so

It is determined by the knowledge that the client has acquired during the counselling sessions which have an effect on the change. While taking the sessions you can give out notes to the clients so that they may get factual knowledge about the problem for example lot of clients do not know about the difference between sadness and depression. By psycho-educating them we are providing them with the knowledge necessary for them to change their current situation.

A change in their attitude towards different situations and problems in life determines the nature and course of their change... If the client's belief system and opinions about the problem has changed and now the client is more open to other's viewpoint, it is a sign of change.

Along with the change in the attitude a change in their action is also important. . As a professional if you are noticing that clients is not being more calm and relaxed towards situations and challenges and meets them head on, it is sign that the change in their situation is emerging.

The above changes will also lead to a change in the result. The client is now able to face the challenging situations by themselves and is able to take decisions and solutions to these situations, is an indicator of a change in the result.

DIFFERENT APPROCHES TO COUNSELLING (SLIDE 7)

Counsellors take a different approach towards their clients. Some might be humanistic; other can be more mechanical while there is a new branch that is developing which is the spiritual approach towards counselling.

Humanistic Approach: Counsellors who take a more humanistic approach revolve their sessions around the client rather than themselves and play a passive role rather an active role. They are available at all times, are supportive and caring and share a more personal relationship with their clients.

Mechanical Approach: Counsellors taking the mechanical approach are more analytical in nature. They are empathetic and candid with their clients but maintain a highly professional relationship

Spiritual Approach: This is a new approach that has gained importance in the western world in recent years, while in the eastern countries it has been a way of life. Prayers, karma, faith and acceptance has a significant impact when counselling clients in our country as religion and spirituality play a very important role as it gives them a ray of hope and a sense of motivation.

TYPES OF PROBLEMS (SLIDE 8)

While dealing with clients they can come up with various types of problems and according to the nature and the type of the problems presented to you by them the counselling session is changed according to it. The nature of the problem may vary throughout the sessions while the client- counsellor relationship is maintained.

Problems can be known and unknown where the client must have foreseen the problems which have the potential to rise up while other can be unknown which the client might not be aware of as he/she might not have expected them to come.

They can also be sure and unsure and critical and common in nature.

It is seen that mostly people are able to deal with problems in a more easier manner which are sure, known and are common as the client might have made a solution plan for them while dealing with problems which are critical, unknown and unsure in nature are more difficult to deal with due to their unpredictability and leaves the client in a state of shock or helplessness.

COUNSELOR- COUNSLEE RELATIONSHIP (SLIDE 9)

The counsellor- counslee relationship is based upon certain principles.

Professional: The relationship is professional in nature where there is contract that is drawn in the beginning of the relationship and after the client feels that he/she is satisfied with the help that is received the relationship is terminated. It is not a lifelong relationship that is to be maintained in most of the cases as the aim is to make the client independent of the counsellor.

Emotional: Since both the client and the counsellor explore a lot of emotions the relationship is very emotional where the counsellor has a deep understanding of the client's feelings and the client has an emotion of trust, hope and happiness attached to the relationship. During this time transference is inevitable due to the emotional nature that both the parties share with one another, but it needs to be maintained in a healthy manner.

Mentoring: The counsellor also serves as a mentor to his/ her client where psycho-education of the client is necessary and to teach them new ways of coping with the problematic situation.

Dominating and Submissive: It is very necessary that the counsellor analyse the personality of the client with head strong clients and those who were forced to enter into the relationship most likely they will tend to dominate the session and while this happens the session can go out of hand. With the more submissive clients it is very important that we take a gentler approach so that they may be able to explore their own emotions and come out of their shell.

Humorous: the relationship needs to be fun and humorous so that the session that you have with them might be more interesting and are conversational. This also helps the client to open up to you better.

COUNSELLING TOOLS (SLIDE 10)

There are various counselling tools that a counsellor might use to gather the necessary information

The counsellor can tell their own stories which might be similar to that of the client in the situation that he is and by telling what the counsellor did to get out of that situation it might help the client to deal with the problem in their own way.

They can have examples of famous people and how they came over hardships. These famous personalities could also be made into role models for the client to give them a sense of motivation to the client.

Counsellors give out motivational quotes to their clients as a form of a message to boost their self-esteem.

They also ask questions which are the most basic tool of counselling through asking questions and paraphrasing the counsellor has a better understanding of the problem.

Case Studies and Research: Counsellors also look up previous case studies and research done by famous psychologists which have been previously done so that they may incorporate these techniques into their own counselling styles.

LISTENING SKILLS (SLIDE 11)

Pay attention. One goal of active listening and being an effective listener is to set a comfortable tone that gives your client an opportunity to think and speak. Allow “wait time” before responding. Don’t cut them off, finish their sentences, or start formulating your answer before they’ve finished.

Withhold judgment. Active listening requires an open mind. As a listener and a leader, be open to new ideas, new perspectives, and new possibilities when practicing active listening. Even when good listeners have strong views, they suspend judgment, hold any criticisms, and avoid arguing or selling their point right away.

Reflect. When you’re the listener, don’t assume that you understand your client correctly or that they know you’ve heard them. Mirror your client’s information and emotions by periodically paraphrasing key points.

Clarify. Don’t be shy to ask questions about any issue that is ambiguous or unclear. As the listener. Open-ended, clarifying, and probing questions are important active listening tools that encourage the client to do the work of self-reflection and problem solving, rather than justifying or defending a position, or trying to guess the “right answer.”

Summarize. Restating key themes as the conversation proceeds confirms and solidifies your grasp of the other person’s point of view. It also helps both parties to be clear on mutual responsibilities and follow-up. Briefly summarize what you have understood while practicing active listening, and ask the other person to do the same.

COMMUNICATION TECHNIQUES (SLIDE 12)

Greet and explain the process to the client as to how the therapeutic process will begin and how it be carried forward.

Assure the client that the confidentiality will be maintained and no information will be given out to a third party.

During the sessions ask clarifying questions that will help you gain important knowledge about the client and his/her problem.

While you are dealing with your clients maintain a cordial and a professional tone. Do not let your facial expressions change with what the client is saying as there is a chance that the client may feel that you are being judgemental of their information. Always maintain a neutral facial expression.

Observe the client's body language and keep your own in check. If at any point you feel that the client is getting uncomfortable or disinterested then make the conversation more interesting and in a positive manner so as to get the client's assurance and attention towards yourself.

While the client is telling you about the problem if at any point you do not understand the client summarise and rephrase what he/she has said.

Explain the goals of the techniques or the homework that you are giving them to avoid any misunderstanding or confusion on the client's part.

Keep yourself flexible about ideas and possibilities.

Balance your listening and talking during the session.

Before you make any decisions on behalf of the client, take their permission.

METHODS OF COUNSELLING (SLIDE 13).

Face to face counselling where the counsellor calls you to his/her clinic and the counselling session takes place face to face.

Counselling sessions also take place through telephone and video call as technology has brought the world closer with one another.

The options of walk in sessions are also available with clients today.

Sessions are also taken at home with senior citizens or with patients with traumatic brain injury who are unable to travel to the centres for the same.

THE COUNSELLING PROCESS (SLIDE 14)

There are three phases in the counselling process the Beginning phase the Action phase and the Ending phase

The Beginning Phase

Physical Preparation

Receiving:

Active Listening

Coping With Feelings

Questioning

Receiving: Here, the counsellor will welcome the clients and his/her attenders and get to know about each other. In this stage of the relationship, it is usually helpful if the counsellor plays the dominant role and helps the client to relax, settle down and focus on why they are there.

Active Listening: Listening is a skill, which every counsellor has to learn and practice to become an effective counsellor. Many times just listening is enough to relieve mental stress and to make the client feel comfort. In the beginning phase active listening enables the counsellor to understand his/her client.

Coping with Feelings: Counselling people often means coping with emotions. Once people in Counselling begin to identify the real issues, they often begin to experience emotional release. A considerable part of the process of helping people in Counselling is concerned with the emotional or feelings side for the person. So, the clients are allowed to express the feelings while sharing information. The counsellor has to develop a deep appreciation for the feelings of the client. The feelings express how they feel about the situation. (Empathetic feeling)

Questioning: plays a major role in the counselling process. There are various ways to get information from the client and questioning is one of the most useful ways of understanding and helping the client.

Action or Problem - solving Phase

The important task in the beginning phase is relationship building and acquiring an understanding of the client's situation. It serves as a ground, for the work that follows in the next phase. The problem solving process involves three major tasks

Summarizing and identifying the clients concern

Establishing realistic goals

Designing steps to achieve this goal

Agreeing A Plan

Summarizing and identifying the clients concern: Summarizing involves identifying and clearly stating the essence of the client's communication. The first step in the problem solving process is to identify clients concern and determine any priority if there are several concerns. This provides the basis on which rest of the problem - solving is built.

Establishing realistic goals: The helping relationship is goal directed and it is negotiated to achieve certain goals. There are two types of goals:

Outcome goal

Process goal.

Outcome Goals: It denotes client's objectives. It will specify what the client will be when the work is completed. Process Goals: It denotes how the work will be done, what are the means for reaching the goals.

Planning Steps to Achieving the Goal:

- a. Identify possible steps to achieve the goal
- b. Evaluate Steps
- c. Work out detailed plan
- d. Implement plan
- e. Evaluate Successes

Agreeing upon a Plan: Out of the process of reaching an idea about how things might be resolved comes the need to identify a practical plan of action. It is one thing knowing what you want to do or change; it is another thing to put those ideas into action.

The Ending Phase

Implementing the plan

Termination

Follow Up

Implementing the plan: The client almost independently of the counsellor carries out this stage of counselling. It is putting in to action of the plan that was discussed in the previous stage. Usually, what the client needs here is support from the counsellor.

Termination: Termination is an inevitable part of the counselling process. The helping relationship is not a permanent one. Its life- time is limited. One should always keep the termination in mind from the beginning and plan for it continuously. When the problem is solved final termination takes place. Termination may at first sight appear to be an end of all relationship with the client. The Counsellor has helped the client

towards self-confidence and decision-making, where the client is much more able to handle problems.

Follow Up: Follow up like evaluation may be a continuous process. It continues from one interview to the next as well as after regular interviews has ended. Before the termination, the counsellor has to see whether the client requires any follow up